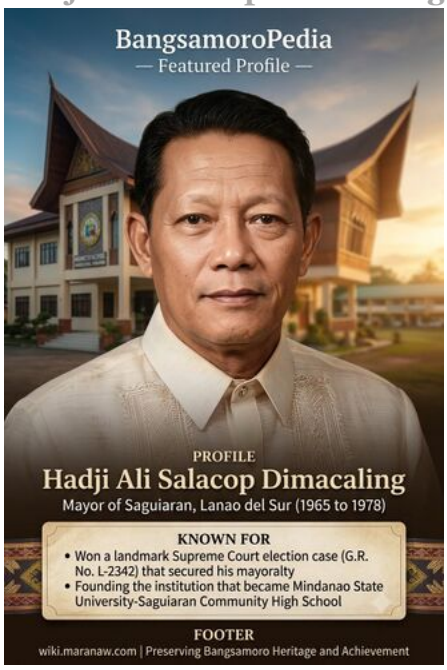
Hadji Ali Salacop Dimacaling

Hadji Ali Salacop Dimacaling was a Filipino politician and civic leader who served as the 11th municipal mayor of Saguiaran, Lanao del Sur, holding office from 1965 to 1978. He is best remembered today for something that outlasted his time in politics: he helped bring the first proper high school to his hometown, an institution that eventually grew into the Mindanao State University-Saguiaran Community High School (MSU-SCHS).

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Hadji Ali Salacop Dimacaling



Title
11th Municipal Mayor of Saguiaran, Lanao del Sur

Term of Office
1965 to 1978

Predecessor
Sheik Aziz Lumna Tanggo

Successor
Hadji Nasser Masorong

Ethnicity
Maranao

Region
Lanao del Sur, Bangsamoro

Notability
Won a landmark Supreme Court election case (G.R. No. L-22342) that secured his mayoralty

Known For
Founding the institution that became Mindanao State University-Saguiaran Community High School

Political Career

The 1963 Election and Legal Mandate

Dimacaling entered prominent local politics during the 1963 Philippine local elections, challenging the political establishment of the incumbent municipal mayor. The election resulted in a highly contested vote count, specifically concerning clerical errors and the validity of tallies in a local precinct.

The political dispute led to a landmark case elevated to the Supreme Court of the Philippines under case number G.R. No. L-22342. On March 31, 1964, the Supreme Court ruled in favor of upholding the corrected judicial count that formalized Dimacaling's election victory. This legal resolution allowed the newly elected leader to officially assume the office of the municipal mayor the following year.

Mayoralty (1965 to 1978)

Dimacaling held the post of municipal mayor of Saguiaran for thirteen years, a tenure that placed him squarely in one of the more turbulent stretches of modern Mindanao history. His time in office overlapped with the final years before martial law and the first half of the Ferdinand Marcos Sr. administration, a period when local governance

across the region had to navigate shifting national politics while still tending to everyday community needs. Throughout his term, Dimacaling kept his focus close to home: infrastructure and education. He stepped down in 1978 and was succeeded by Hadji Nasser Masorong.

Institutional Contributions to Education

If there is one legacy that defines Dimacaling's time as mayor, it is education. Before he took office, families in Saguiaran had no real local option for secondary schooling. Sending a child to high school meant sending them somewhere else entirely, often far from home.

Establishment (1967 to 1969)

Dimacaling worked directly with Dr. Antonio Isidro, the founding president of Mindanao State University (MSU), to organize what would become the Saguiaran Community High School. In its earliest days, the school ran under the Department of Education, Culture, and Sports (DECS) District Supervisor, and it leaned heavily on teachers borrowed from the Saguiaran Central Elementary School just to keep classes running.

Integration into the MSU System (1973)

By 1973, Dimacaling had negotiated something far more lasting: the permanent absorption of the high school into the Mindanao State University system as an official External Unit. That move shifted the school's funding and oversight to the national university system, which meant Saguiaran finally had stable, state-supported secondary education instead of a makeshift arrangement held together by goodwill and borrowed teachers.

Family and Lineage

Dimacaling came from a family with deep roots in law and public service across Lanao del Sur, and that thread continued well past his own term in office. His paternal grandson, Yasser M. Salacop, CGM, went on to serve as an administrator and academic official at the Mindanao State University Main Campus in Marawi City. Other members of his family, across his own generation and the one after, have served as a Regional Trial Court (RTC) Judge for Agusan and Lanao del Sur, and as succeeding municipal mayors of Saguiaran.

Historical Legacy

In Saguiaran's local history, Dimacaling holds a formal place in the municipal roster of executive leaders, recognized for his role in the town's post-independence governance. Local historians point to his partnership with early MSU figures like Dr. Antonio Isidro as a turning point, one that helped weave the Maranao community of Saguiaran more fully into the country's national secular education system.

References

- LGU Saguiaran Public Records
- Saguiaran Community High School, institutional records
- Yasser M. Salacop, family records
- Hadji Aziz Lumna Tango v. Hon. Cristobal Alejandro and Hadji Salacop Dimacaling, G.R. No. L-22342, March 31, 1964

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